

Be**T**here

Taking the pain out of friend group meetups.

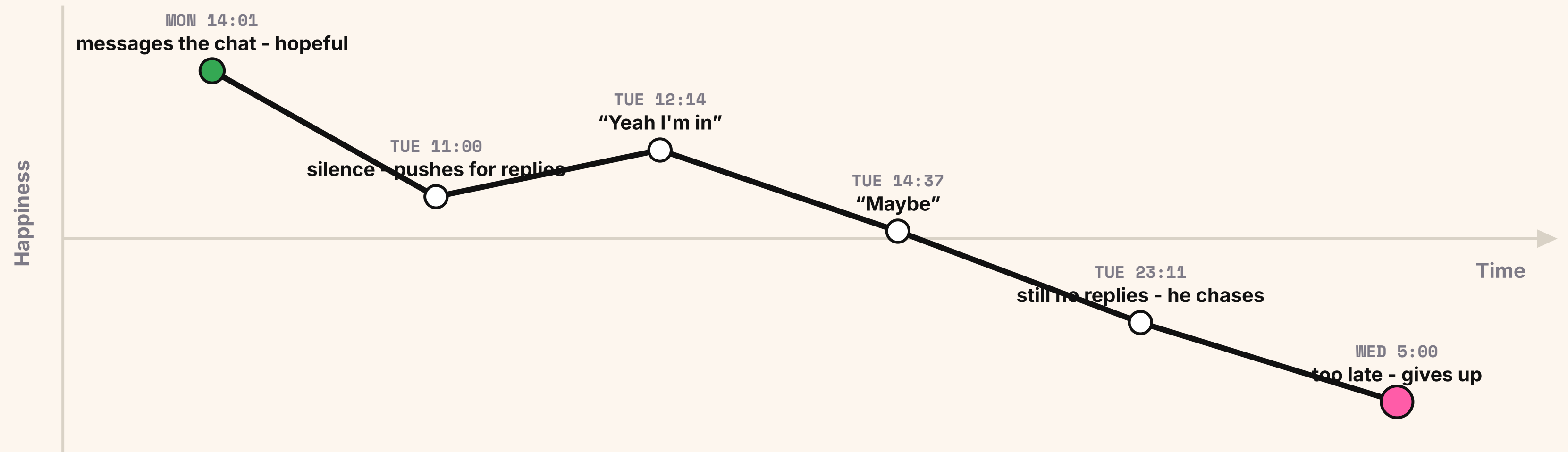
Meet **Vasanth**

- Age 21
- Studies Law at St. Andrews
- Enjoys playing volleyball and board games
- Loves to cook for his friends
- Extroverted and reliable

The **organiser**.



Vasanth's Christmas break, mapped as he felt it



THE ORGANISER'S PROBLEM

Vasanth loves to meet his friends, but organising is difficult and chasing replies from group members is frustrating.

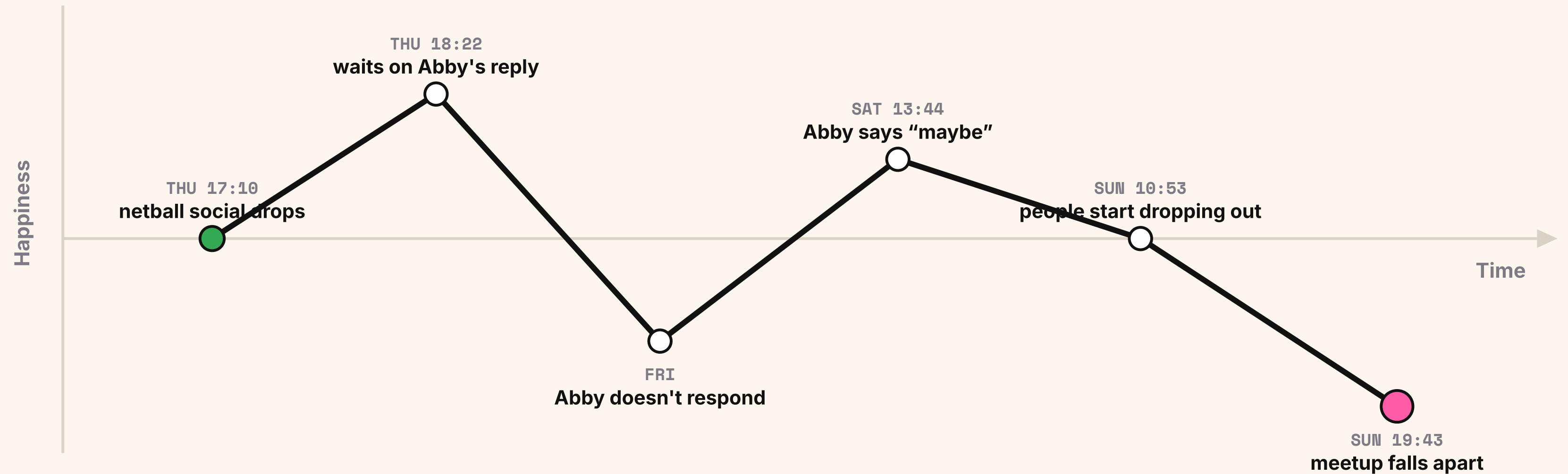
Meet **Milly**

- Age 19
- Studies English Literature at St. Andrews
- Likes to play cello and read
- Recently joined her university's netball society
- Shy and introverted

The **passive** participant.



Milly's netball social, mapped as she felt it



THE PARTICIPANT'S PROBLEM

Milly would love to engage with her netball society's socials more, but she is *hesitant* because she wants to be sure her friends are *going too*.

RESEARCH

**To better understand this problem, we interviewed
university students about their social lives.**

“

If I drummed up the plan, and it's taken **considerable time**, looking at logistics, pricing, whether everyone's okay with it, and then it falls through after all of that, that's **quite frustrating**.

Eddie, 21 - the organiser

3rd year Psychology at Goldsmiths





“

As days went past, [the meetup] got more drawn out, second thoughts crept in, and more and more people ended up pulling out.

Chloe, 19 - the passive participant

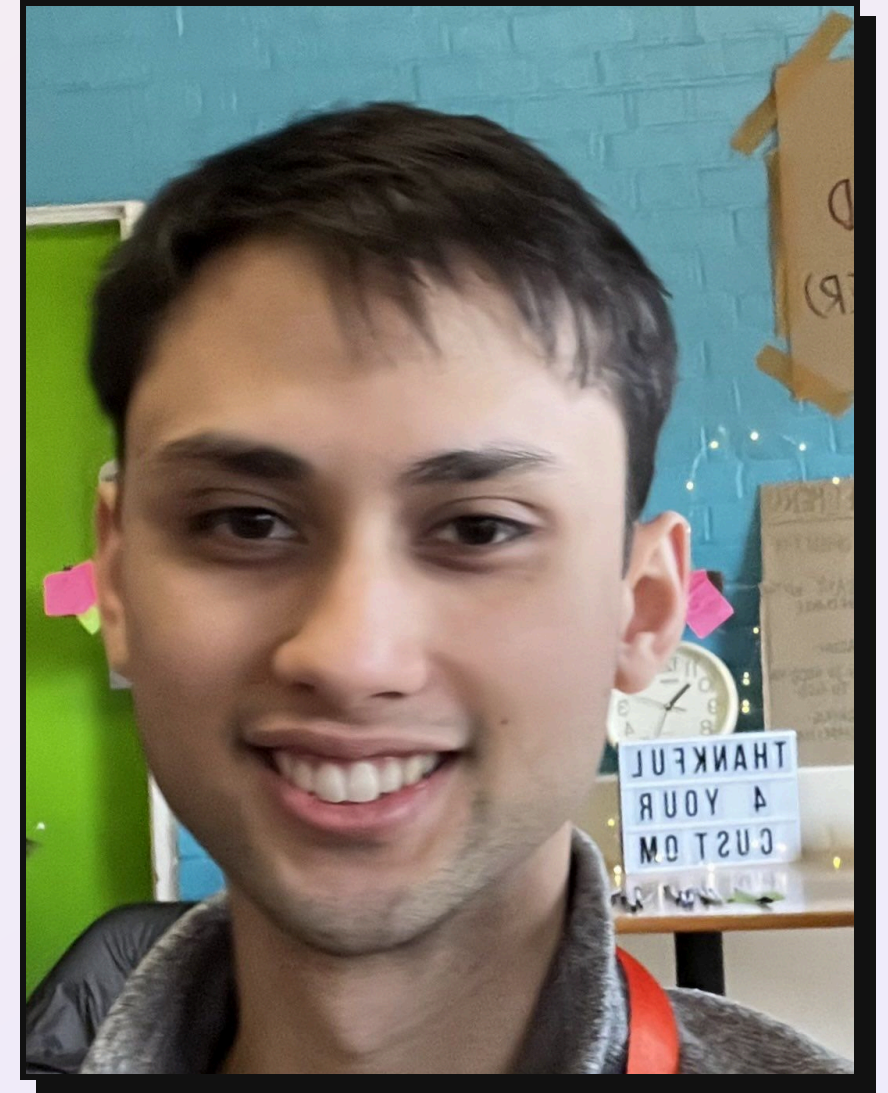
2nd Year International Relations at King's College

“

If [I'm meeting] a friend of a friend, my attendance is **conditional** on my friend being there. I'll wait for them to respond first, then decide.

Luca, 20 - the passive participant

BioChem at Oxford



Two key stakeholder **groups**

1. SUGGESTORS

One sided and exhausting. *Awkward* to push for replies.

2. PARTICIPANTS

Uncertainty *compounds* uncertainty. Some people's participation is *contingent* on others.

50%+

of our 47 survey respondents said **over a third** of meet-ups never made it out of the chat.

60%

said the meet-up time gets moved **half the time or more.**

87%

send a **maybe** or **delay** their response to a plan they are unsure about.

A DECADE AGO

7%



TODAY

22%

of young people have one or no close friends.

25%+

of lonely young people have sought therapy.

BACP, *Loneliness impacting majority of young people's mental health*,

[<https://www.bacp.co.uk/news/news-from-bacp/2025/20-june-loneliness-impacting-majority-of-young-people-s-mental-health/>]

OPPORTUNITY - HOW MIGHT WE

How might we reduce **hesitancy in undergraduate friend groups when planning to meet up so that groups go from frustrating '**maybe**' responses to a clear **consensus**?**

User Story

As a social member of my friend group who tends to organise things

I want to be able to easily suggest meetups to my friends

So that I can see my friends more without the frustration of chasing responses



Our initial design

Suggest a meet

GROUP

Lithuanian Study Group

Climbing Group

TITLE

Bouldering

LOCATION

Vauxwall East

DATE

2026-06-10

TIME

14:00

Create

Meetups

Groups

Account

Suggest a meet

LOCATION optional

TenPin Bexleyheath

NOTES optional

Come at 6, we'll eat around 8

WHEN

Flexible

Fixed

Offer a time or two; people react and it locks at a deadline.

Tomorrow eve

This Sat

Sat eve

Next week

Thu, Jun 4

10:15 PM

+ Add a time

LOCKS IN

Locks Wed 3 Jun, 22:15

the evening before - best-supported time wins

Change

Float it

Add a title to continue

Meetups

Groups

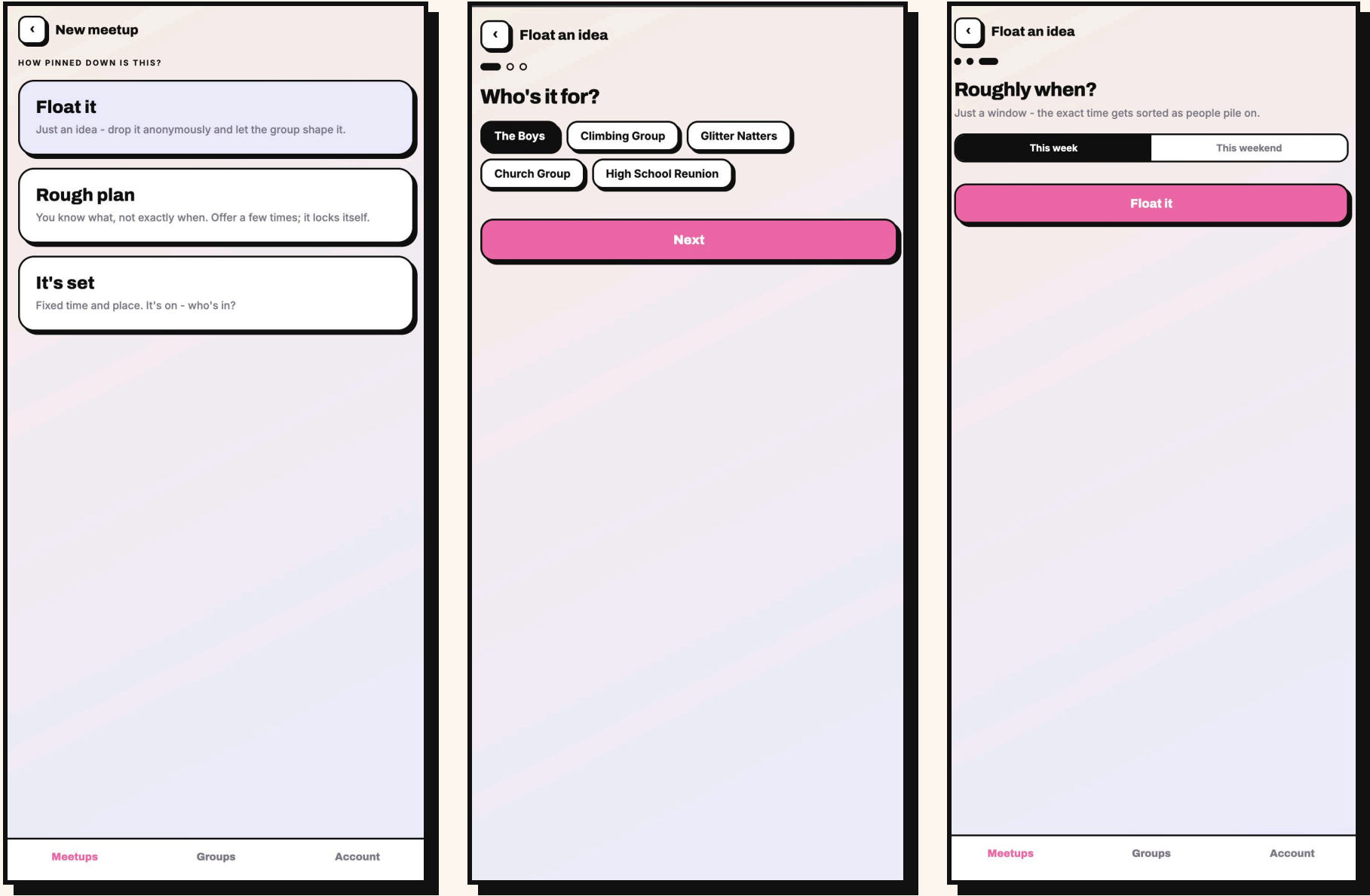
Account

“I could see this being used to just check for people's availability - sending out a vague idea of ‘I want to meetup’ and seeing what everyone wants to do.”

“Having a set time seems quite restrictive - it would be nice to agree on a time within the group.”

“It's not immediately obvious why there's a flexible and fixed option for times.”

After some refinement



“
These options are quite confusing - I don't really understand when you would ever use the rough plan option.
- usability test

User Story

As a new and introverted member of a friend group

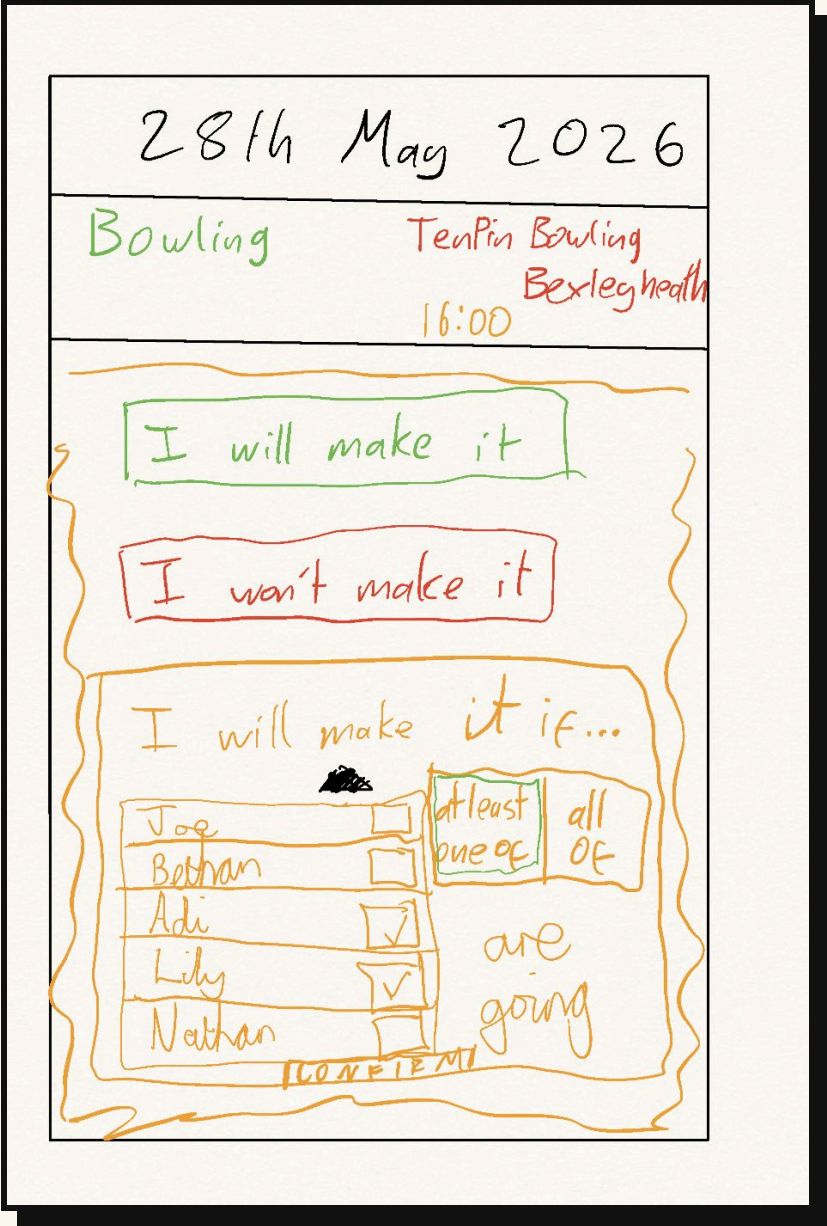
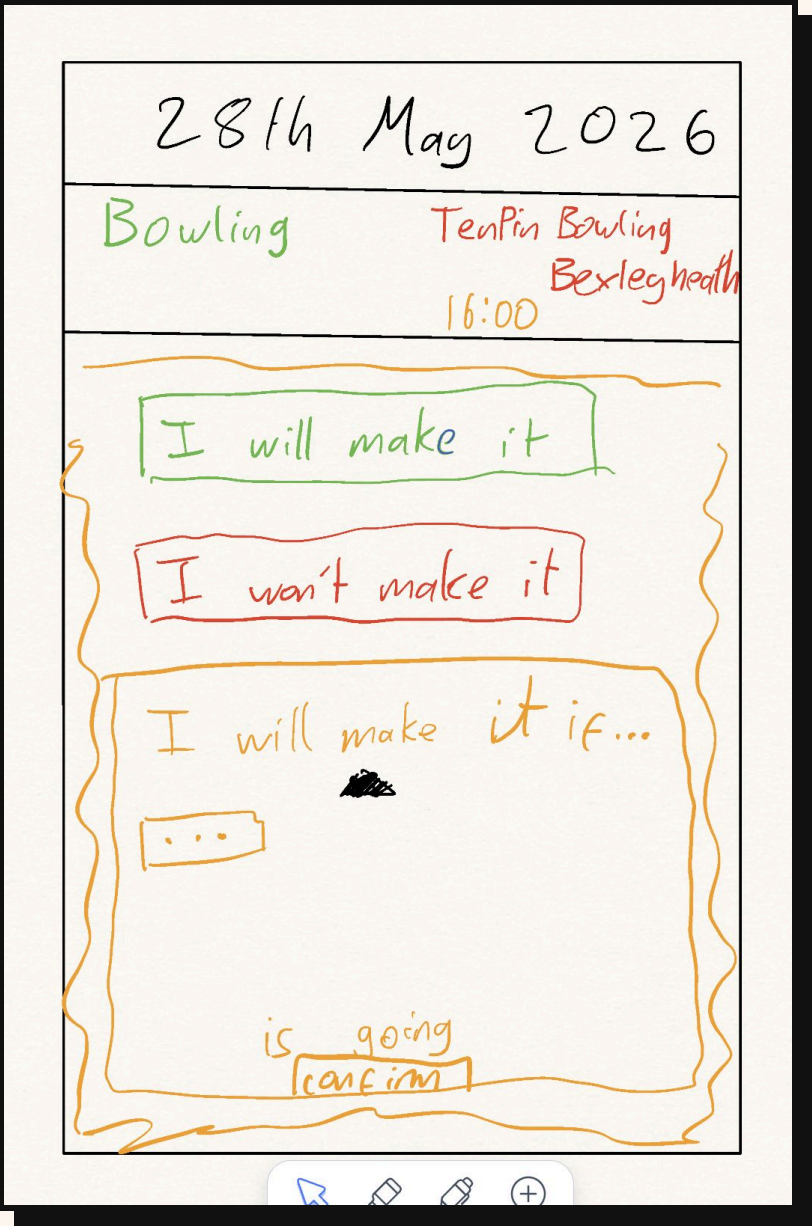
I want to only attend social events if I already know people going

So that I feel comfortable



Initial mock-up

Conditional attendance - "I'll go if..."



"It's either I'll go if one person goes, or if a group of people go. I don't think I'd need something this complex."

"There's gotta be an and/or type thing with the ifs - I'll go if Adi and Lily are going, or if either of them are going."

"These two options are definitely the things I'll be thinking about if it were a meeting where I'd conditionally go."

User Story

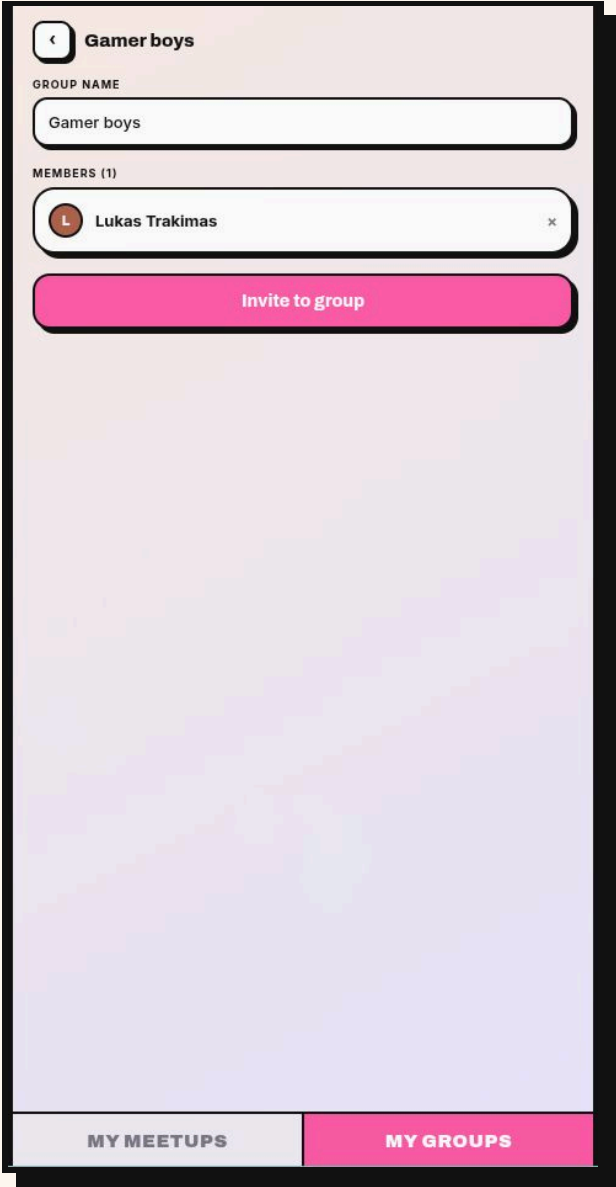
As someone wanting to organise a meetup for my friends

I don't want to have to convince people to download a new app

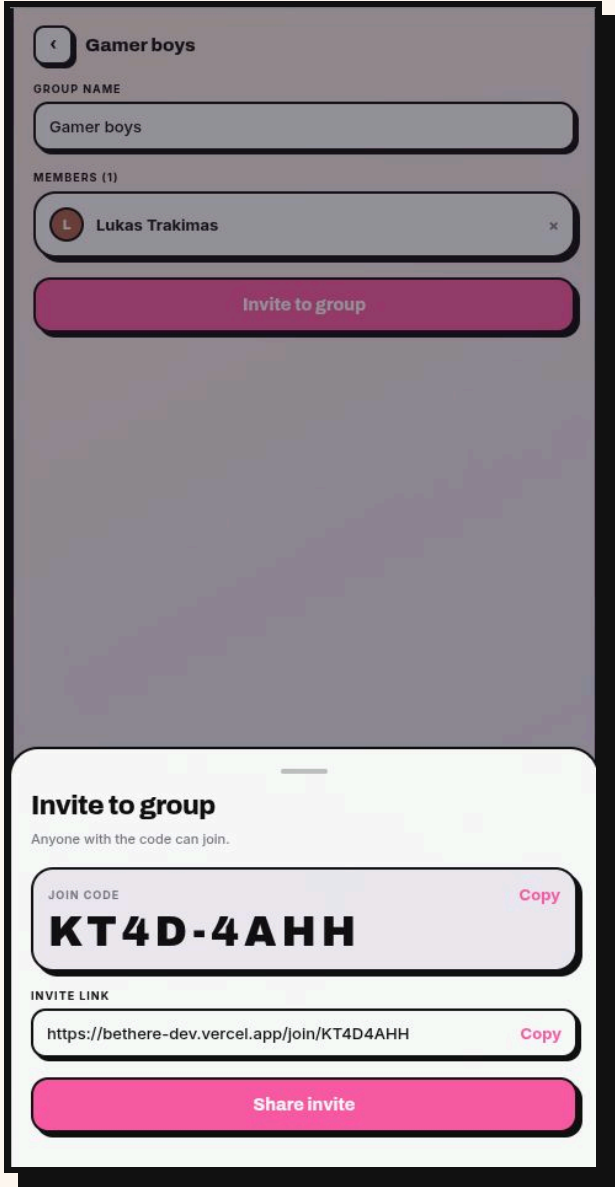
So that I can save time and avoid frustration



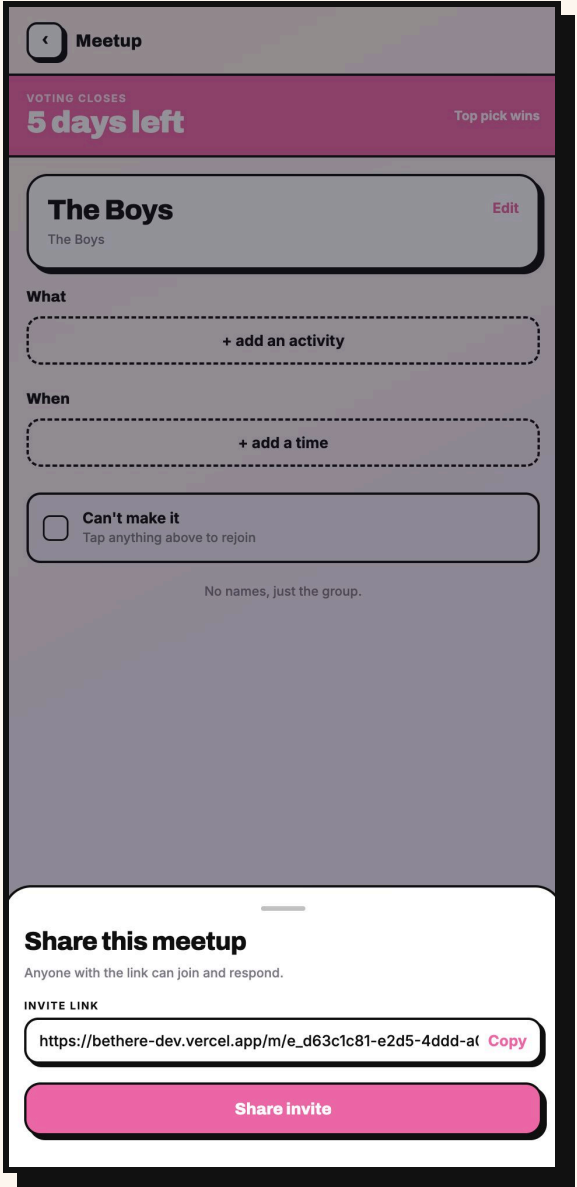
Our initial design



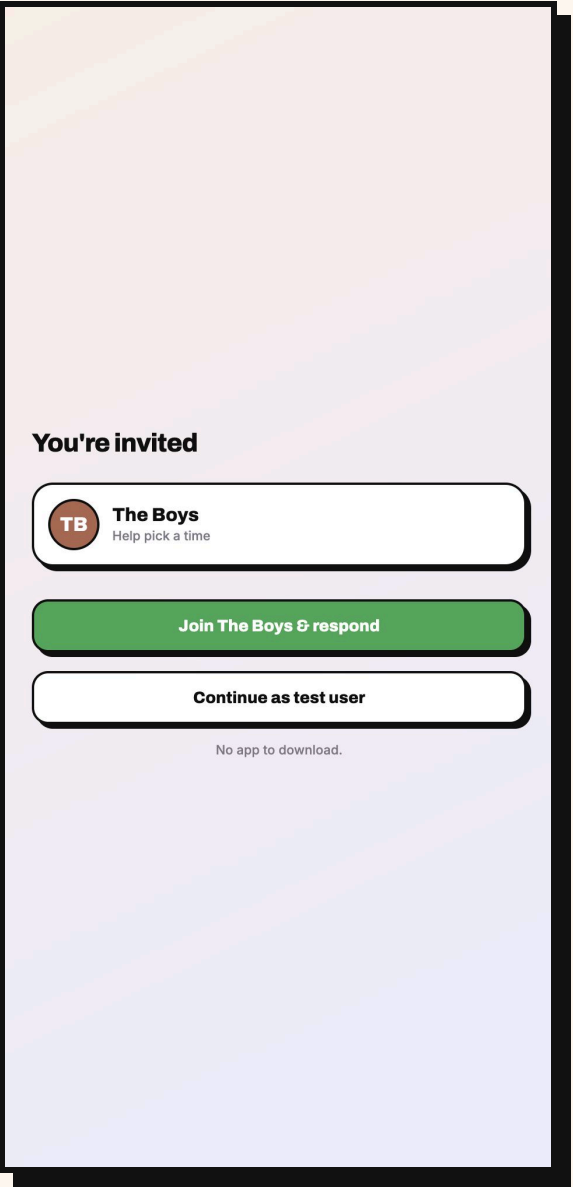
Create a group



Invite with a join code



Share the meetup



Join - no app to download



IN HIS WORDS

Hear it from Luca

on onboarding friends

User Story

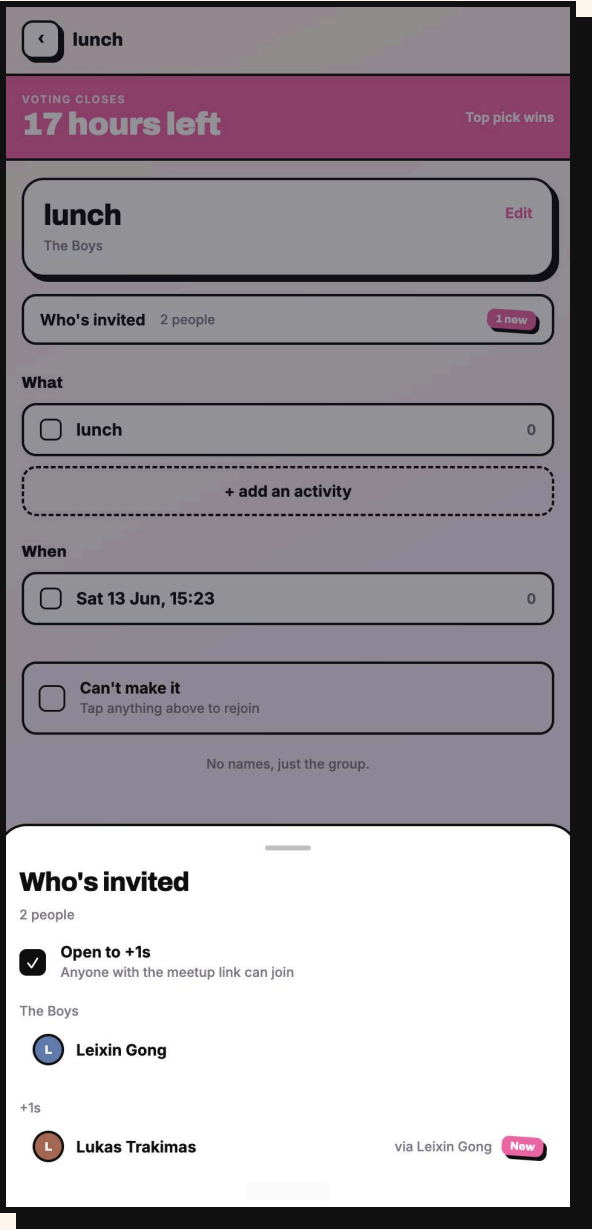
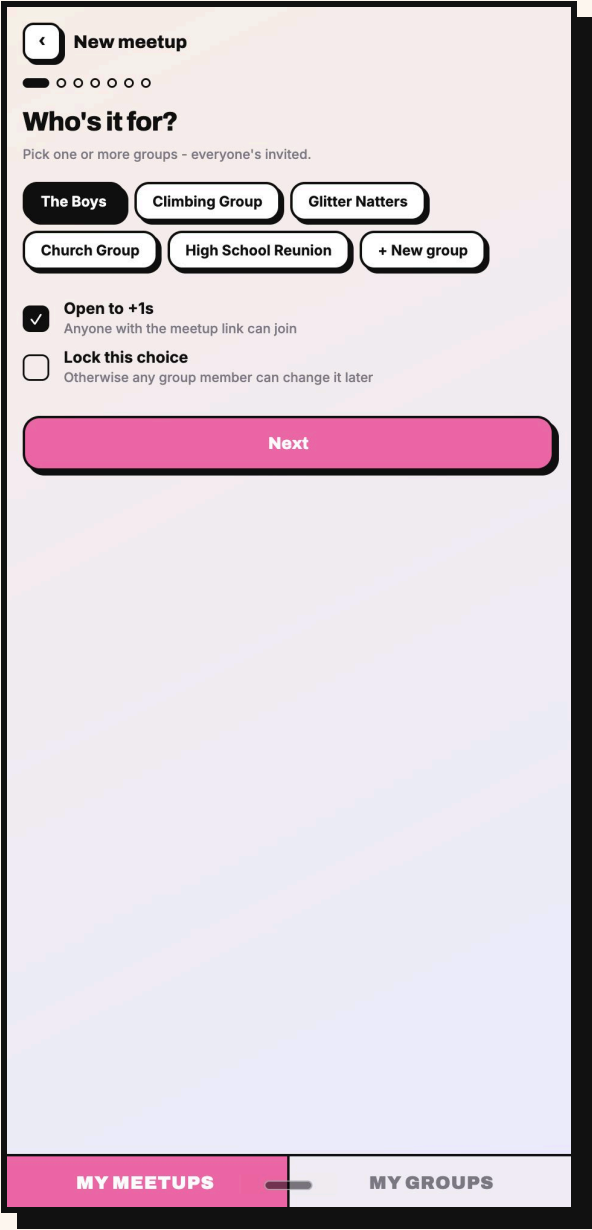
As a student in numerous friend groups

I want to suggest meetups bringing together several groups of people, and to allow friends to bring along their friends

So that I can invite people I don't know who would improve the event



After some refinement



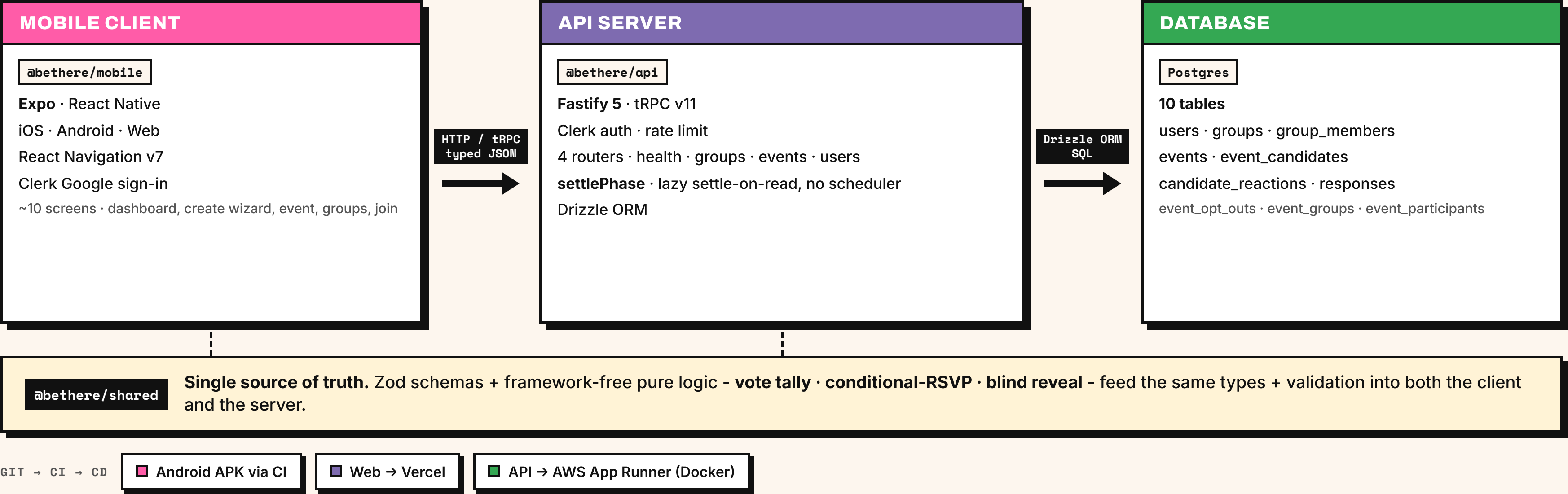
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Going to a group event is a lot about the chemistry between the group. If someone was there I didn't really know, it might ruin that.

- usability test

Implementation

System Architecture



Why this **stack**

TypeScript + pnpm monorepo

One language across client, server, and shared logic. Refactors are **type-checked end to end**.

tRPC v11 + Zod

A **fully type-safe API** with zero hand-written types or codegen. One schema validates server input and types the client.

Expo / React Native

One codebase ships to **iOS, Android, and web** - so we could test with real users on whatever device they already had.

Fastify 5

A lightweight, fast Node server - a thin, low-overhead host for the tRPC layer.

Postgres + Drizzle ORM

Groups, votes, and RSVPs are inherently relational, so the database gives us **integrity for free**, with typed SQL.

Clerk

Managed auth with **real Google OAuth** - we don't roll our own identity or security.

Git → GitHub Actions CI/CD

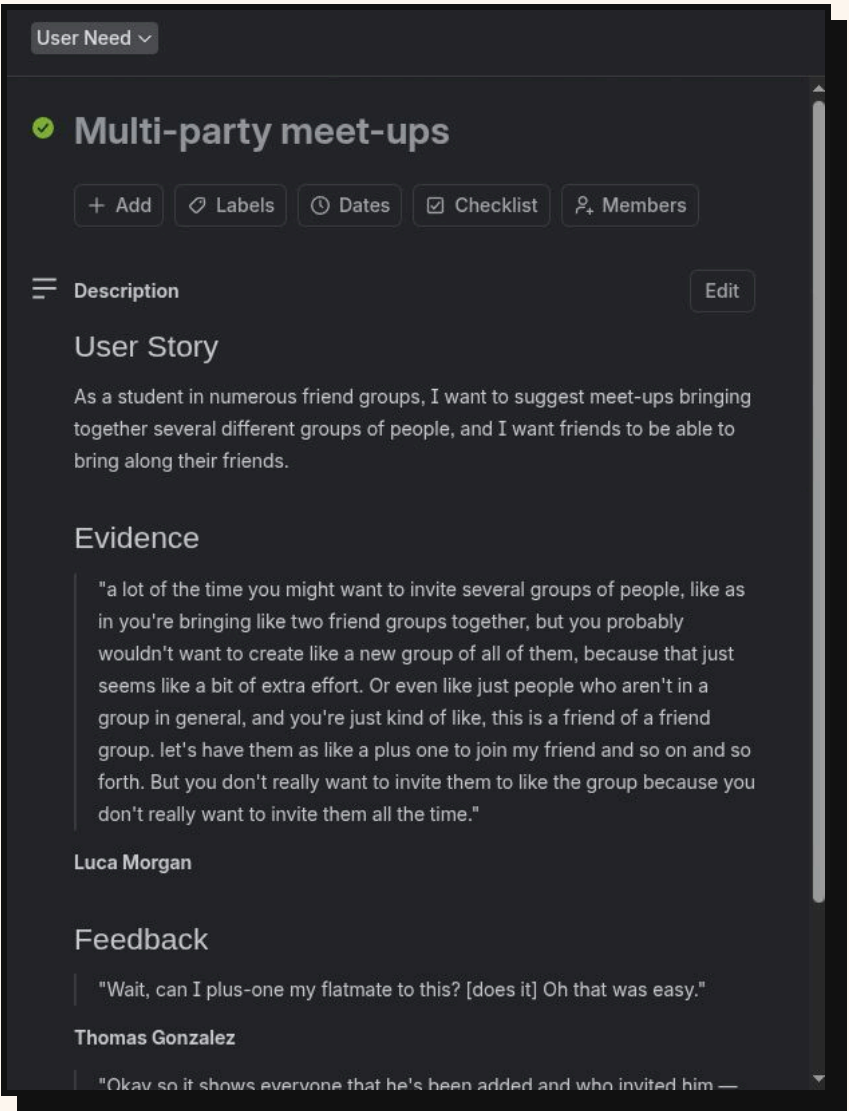
Lint, typecheck, and tests run on **every change**, with continuous deployment to AWS App Runner (API) and Vercel (web).

What went well

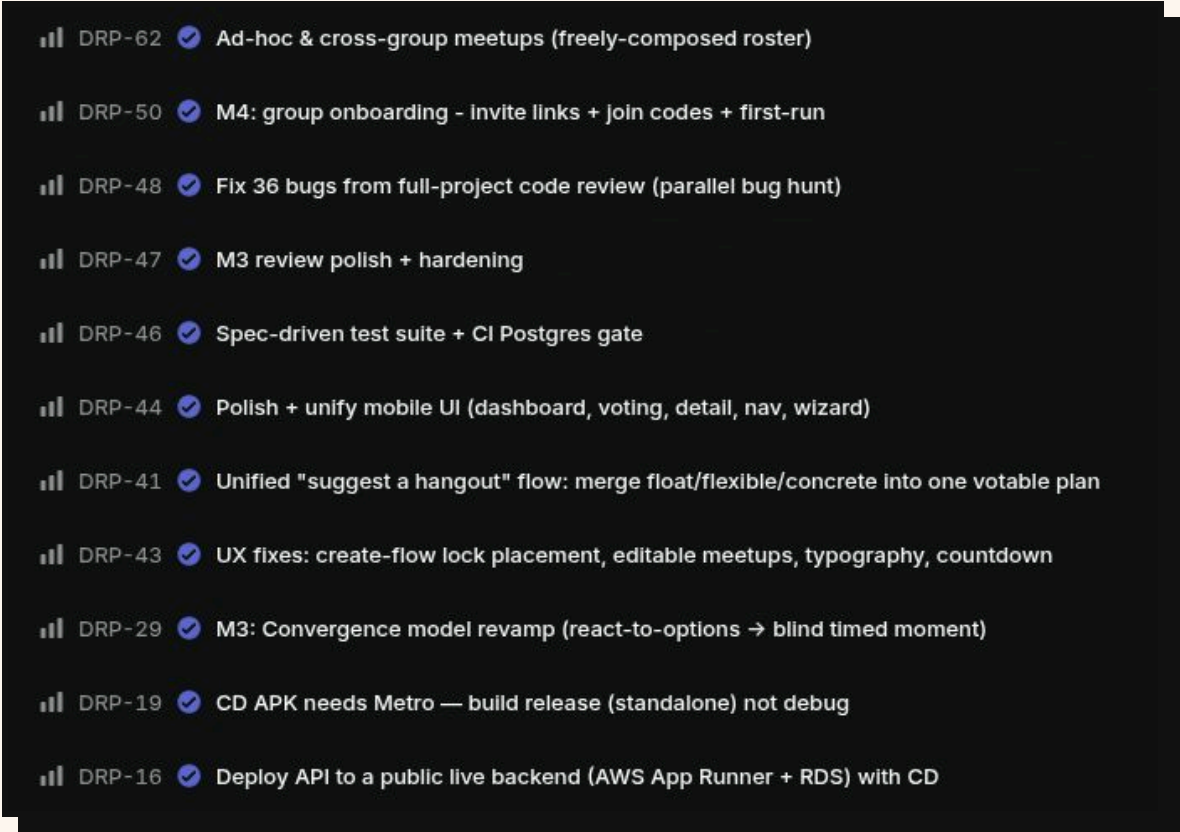
Continuous feedback from **new and **recurring** users gave us diverse insights into how the problem is actually solved.**

Letting users plan **real meetups with their friends using BeThere helped identify the pain points of the app.**

Agile development



Trello for mapping user needs.



Linear for engineering issues.

What we would do differently

Testing: a stronger test suite with wider code coverage would've prevented bugs from recurring.

Sprint planning: earlier iterations were too feature-focused - user stories were an afterthought.

Impact

User impacts & **benefits**



Vasanth

- ✓ Goes out with his friends regularly, despite his busy schedule.
- ✓ Feels less lonely.

Milly

- ✓ Is more comfortable with meeting new people.
- ✓ Has begun suggesting meetups of her own.

Wider **impacts**

If fewer plans die in the chat, the benefit ripples outward.

MENTAL HEALTH

University counselling services

Less isolation to pick up.

PUBLIC HEALTH

NHS mental health provision

Loneliness is a population-level cost.

COMMUNITY

University societies

More socials that actually happen.

LOCAL ECONOMY

Local venues

Plans that land fill seats.

Looking ahead

**Milly's availability may change after confirming
she'll BeThere**

People who will go if Milly goes want to be notified
she might not make it.

Plus-ones are still an **awkward** problem.

Vasanth may welcome plus-ones to his meetup, but there are some people he would prefer not to see there.

Meetup logistics are full of nuance - we cannot capture every case.

An in-app chat dedicated to the meetup, available after confirmation, would let the group settle the details.